



Lake Malawi

A large, deep lake at the southern end of Africa's Great Rift Valley with a remarkably diverse population of fish



Also known as Nyasa and Niassa, Lake Malawi is the southernmost and third largest of the East African Great Lakes, lying between Malawi, Tanzania, and Mozambique. It is about 360 miles (580 km) long, up to 47 miles (75 km) wide, and reaches a depth of more than 2,300 ft (700 m). The lake is fed by the Ruhuhu River, from the north, and several smaller rivers. From the southern end flows its only

outlet, the Shire River, a tributary of the Zambezi. Lake Malawi runs north-to-south, occupying a single basin in part of the southern end of the Great Rift Valley (see pp.184–87). Above its north and east shores rise steep mountain slopes, some covered by thick forest. The much flatter and shallower shores of the southern end of the lake feature many white, sandy beaches.

Multitudes of fish

Lake Malawi's waters and shores provide a variety of habitats and are home to many animals including crocodiles, hippopotamuses, and the African fish eagle. The lake is best known for containing as many as 3,000 species of fish—more than any other lake on Earth.



▷ WINGED ARCHITECT

The male village weaver builds a dense nest out of grass and leaves. Leaving an opening at the bottom, it suspends the nest from a tree branch.



△ LAKE OF STARS

The explorer David Livingstone called Lake Malawi the Lake of Stars, due to the dazzling reflections off its still waters. However, it is also known for the violent gales that blow through.